

SCAFFOLD

SUPPORTS TERTIARY WHY

FOR WHAT-HOW · HOW-WHAT

The Assumption Audit

A checklist that surfaces the unexamined premises baked into a plan, before execution effort is invested in them.

The beliefs get listed, tested, and owned on purpose.

THE DRAIN

Every plan encodes beliefs: about demand, about people, about what stays constant. Surfacing them is WHY work, questioning the frame rather than the contents, and for tertiary WHY profiles it does not happen unprompted. Untested assumptions fail silently, and flawless execution amplifies them.

WHAT THIS TOOL DOES

The audit is a procedural pass, thirty minutes against a finished plan, that extracts the assumptions the way a checklist extracts details. Each belief gets written down, rated for confidence and consequence, and either accepted out loud or assigned the cheapest available test. Rigor doing the job of instinct.

The audit prompts

- 1 What must be true for this plan to work? List everything, obvious included.
- 2 Which of these beliefs are inherited, from a predecessor, a template, a habit, rather than tested?
- 3 Which single assumption, if wrong, does the most damage?
- 4 What evidence would change our mind, and are we positioned to see it?
- 5 What is the cheapest test for the riskiest belief?

HOW TO USE IT

- 1 **Audit the finished plan, fresh.** Assumptions hide best from their authors. Do the pass a day after planning, not during.
- 2 **Write every belief, however obvious.** "Obviously" is the costume assumptions wear. The obvious ones fail hardest.
- 3 **Rate on two axes.** Confidence and consequence. High-consequence, low-confidence items are the audit's product.
- 4 **Test or accept, in writing.** Cheapest test for the risky ones; explicit acceptance for the rest. Silent assumptions are the only forbidden kind.

WHAT IT WON'T DO

The audit finds the beliefs; it does not adjudicate them, judgment and sometimes real research still follow. And it examines the plan's premises, not its purpose, pair it with the Reframe Deck when the deeper question is whether this is the right problem at all.

IN THE KIT

Audit worksheet

Two-axis rating grid

Cheapest-test menu

PAIRS WELL WITH

Tool 23 Problem Reframe Deck · **Tool 6** Edge-Case Question Bank · **Tool 30** Pre-Mortem Protocol